

While buying such a big house was destructive to their financial health, the polar opposite wouldn't have been helpful either. If Alex and Shelby had decided to save hundreds of thousands of dollars by purchasing a dilapidated shack in the middle of a cornfield, they wouldn't exactly be living their best lives.

Although purchasing a McMansion outside of your price range is a problem, getting so hung up on the numbers that you buy a house you absolutely hate is equally silly. We know that the average homeowner lives in their first property for five to seven years, and generally speaking, the younger they are, the less time they will live in their current home. Therefore, you should buy a house that you can enjoy—or, at the very least, tolerate—for five to seven years.

This is the exit option on which we'll spend the least amount of time, since hardly anyone will buy a house that doesn't meet their lifestyle expectations. However, we'll sometimes come across folks who are so overeager to max out their savings potential that they end up in a (metaphorical) cornfield.

Everyone has different priorities when it comes to houses. Whether yours include the year it was built, the school district, proximity to your workplace, square footage, kitchen updates, or the space and potential to start your own backyard beekeeping hobby, you must understand what is a “want” and what is a “need.”

If you, your partner, or your family are unhappy with the location, build, size, lack of beekeeping space, or other unchangeable aspects of your house, you're not reaping one of the best benefits of home buying: the freedom to prioritize the things that are most important to you! You're also putting your money at risk, since you'll feel increasing pressure to move out, and you might make decisions that are against your long-term interests.

Not everything has to be perfect, but you should keep your needs in mind. Just make sure to...bee smart about such a long-term choice.

EXIT STRATEGY NO. 2: KEEP THE PROPERTY AS A CASH-FLOWING RENTAL